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Color pushes fashion industry to brighter era

Exciting pastels and simmering shades dominate industry

By Stacey Tiedge
Gannett News Service

A peek into fashion designers' and color forecasters' crystal ball reveals a color outlook for the millennium that is both brighter and far more technological than what we've seen before.

"Technology will allow us to create new color effects," says Leatrice Eiseman, director of the Pantone Color Institute.

The staff of Pantone Inc., a Carlstadt, N.J., company that defines color for producers of textiles, coatings, plastics and graphics, interviewed fashion designers about the colors they chose for their spring collections.

According to Pantone, women's fashion in spring 1998 is awash in bright pastels like Powder Blue, Fandango Pink, Blue Turquoise, Opal Gray and Golden Cream.

It's a turn toward the brighter side of the spectrum for designers who had been enamored of minimal neutrals during the early part of the decade.

"People were concerned coming out of the whoop-de-do '80s," Eiseman says. "The instant reaction was the no color look: bland, beige. When people get concerned, they don't want to make a color statement. They figure they can't wear it next year. It's psychological and emotional."

But as the economy improved, color started to show its head again.

"The take now is not boring middle tones," Eiseman said. "We're in between brights and mid-tones — brightened pastels."

At the collections, designer Jill Stuart showed a spring line of lilac, iris and mauve combined with purple, khaki green, cornflower blue and silver gray.

Anna Sui brought bright colors from the beach, mixing hot pink with bright orange and bubble gum pink with brown. Susan Lazar went deeper with natural and jewel tones while Ralph Lauren used soft and sophisticated color: pale pink, gray and blue combined with ivory and cream.

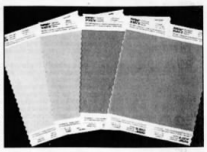
So how do the designers decide where to go with color?

It starts with color forecasters like Roseann Forde.

Forde, a fashion director for DuPont Fibers in New York City, travels the world seeking out fabric and fashion trends that could be brought to the United States with the help of fibers created by DuPont.

Forde's expertise earned her a seat on the women's wear color forecasting panel for the Color Association of the United States.

The association is one of several that uses panels of experts to forecast colors for such categories as menswear, women's wear, children's wear and home furnishings.



Color palette: The fashion world will introduce more shades as we head toward the year 2000.



GREG DeRUITER/Lansing State Journal

Showered with gifts: Have fun with traditional candies, cute stuffed toys or greeting cards — from romantic to contemporary — this Valentine's Day. Don't say we didn't warn you; you have five days to shop before the big date.

Won't you be mine?

Valentine's Day is fast approaching – have you ordered your flowers?

By Tracey Birkenhauer
Lansing State Journal

Valentine's Day isn't just for lovers anymore.

Anyone in your life can be valentine-worthy these days, whether it's your parent, sibling or boss.

Americans will buy nearly 1 billion valentines this year, making Valentine's Day the second-largest seasonal card-sending occasion of the year. (Christmas is first, with 2.6 billion cards).

Women buy about 85 percent of valentines, according to American Greetings Corp., maker of 2,000 varieties of Valentine's Day cards. Valentine buyers' median age is 48, while the recipients is 46.

But valentines don't merely have to consist of cards. You can get the usual dozen long-stem roses ($45 and up), lingerie ($20 and up) or a stuffed animal ($2 and up).

If you go the flower route, order early.

Many florists require orders at least three days in advance and still won't guarantee delivery on Feb. 14.

If you buy your honey the same thing every year, maybe it's time for something unique — something that looks like you spent lots of time and money, even if you didn't.

"You can put red balloons and paper around anything and you can say it's Valentine's Day," said Nancy Achenbach, owner of Ma-Ah's in Lansing.

Her store offers nontraditional valentines, from borderline raunchy cards to sweets — including truffles and jelly beans — to plastic handcuffs that declare: "Love Cuffs," "Prisoner of Love" or "Take me, I'm yours."

Valentine balloons and candy are the best sellers.

But some people like to be a little different," Achenbach said. "We'll sell plenty of handcuffs and funny cards."

You can offer the gift of you for Valentine's Day by giving professional portraits of yourself, with or without your significant other or family.

"Portraits are something that show your personality and feelings," said Tom Nakielski, owner of Lights On Studio. "If you love somebody, they should have some memory to carry around with them — or something on their wall."

For February, Lights On Studio offers 50 percent discounts on photo sessions and 15 percent off on all orders. With the discount, sessions are from $20 to $60 and photos are $25 and up.

Lights On has a special deal for same-sex couples. They get 75 percent off photo sessions and 15 percent off orders.

"I want same-sex couples to be comfortable, to behave just like a husband and wife would," Nakielski said. "I want them to be themselves."

If you don't have time for photo sessions or order-ahead flowers, you can simplify your valentine shopping at discount department stores. Target, Meijer and Kmart have aisles brimming with holiday candy, cards and stuffed toys.

It's one-stop shopping at a modest price. Target has stuffed animals for $2.50, candies or several varieties of red-and-white candy for less than $3.

If you're willing to spend more to declare your love or appreciation, Medawar Jewelers on Saginaw Street might have what you want.

Diamond heart earrings ($40 and up) and pendants ($80-$1,000) are big sellers this time of year.

Them, of course, there are diamond stud earrings ($90-$1,250).

"They're popular year-round," said saleswoman Salli Farhat.

Please see VALENTINE, 2D

What's new

Olestra is coming back

Frito Lay, Proctor & Gamble and other companies are will start marketing fat-free foods made with olestra in coming weeks.

Olestra is the fat substitute that in previous trials has caused diarrhea and cramps. If your stomach starts churning when you're chomping on some fat-free Fritos, the Center for Science in the Public Interest has a toll-free number: 1-888-OLESTRA.

The center is a nonprofit health-advocacy organization that focuses on nutrition and food safety. It's opposed to olestra, but not all the substitutes. When you call the group's olestra number, you report your problem confidentially to the Food and Drug Administration.

Entertainment

Rosie, and maybe a van

For Cynthia Sparks of East Lansing, there's been good news. She won a free trip to California and she'll be on national TV today.

Now there might be some better news. She could win a Chevy minivan.

Sparks is one of the finalists in a "Rosie O'Donnell Show" contest, which is a fund-raiser for a General Motors breast-cancer campaign.

Today (4 p.m. on Channel 6), she'll be one of five viewers to appear on O'Donnell's show. One of them will win a van.

Auditions seek black actresses

There are times when theater roles lack balance. Onstage, you see a bunch of white guys.

Now comes some counterbalance. All eight of the roles in "Long Time Since Yesterday" are for African-American women.

Director Vanessa Cunningham-Sanders is seeking two girls (ages 12-14) and six women (ages 18 and up). This is the final night for auditions.

That's at 7 p.m. at Riverwalk Theatre. You also can look at the script in advance at the theater; call 482-5700.

Tickets start for Elton John

Elton John has been almost everywhere lately, from news shows to concert halls to the sidewalk outside the "Today" studio. So shouldn't he go to Ann Arbor?

He will, soon. His Crisler Arena concert is set for April 25. Tickets go on sale at 10 a.m. today for $44.50, at (313) 763-8587. They're also at Ticketmaster (484-0656), which can add more than $5 per ticket for handling.



John

Quick hits

The Haslett High School Concert Choir has a free concert tonight. That's at 6 p.m. at the school, as a warmup for a concert the group will be giving at a choral-director convention.

On this date in:



1964, The Beatles made their first live American television appearance on "The Ed Sullivan Show."

1971, the Apollo 14 spacecraft returned to Earth after man's third landing on the moon.

1984, Soviet leader Yuri Andropov died at age 69, less than 15 months after succeeding Leonid Brezhnev. He was succeeded by Konstantin Chernenko.

1993, NBC News announced it had settled a defamation lawsuit brought by General Motors over the network's "inappropriate demonstration" of a fiery pickup truck crash on its "Dateline NBC" program.

Written and compiled by Tracey Birkenhauer, Mike Hughes and Robin Swartz.

Surf on African-American Web sites

Several networks make home pages for adults and kids

By Bill O'Brian
The Washington Post

As the Internet grows, it increasingly is fostering networks of like-minded people, whether for practical ends like commerce or for broader goals such as building political communities.

An array of Web sites attempts to help African Americans on both levels — from employment opportunities to culture and literature.

One place to start is Everythingblack (www.everythingblack.com), a sort of mega-mall home page. It displays 12 broad categories — from arts and humanities to business, entertainment and travel — that offer links to hundreds of Web sites, including African-American community news outlets all over the country.

There are numerous specialized sites, too:

■ Mosaicbooks.com/The Black Literary Showcase (www.mosaicbooks.com), an affiliate of online bookstore Amazon.com, features summaries and recommendations on current black and Hispanic literature.

■ Black Facts Online (www.blackfacts.com) is a fledgling database/search engine that aspires to be "Your Internet Resource of Black History Information."

■ Black Urban Professionals Online (www.buppie.com) provides parenting tips, a resume databank, guidance on personal finance, and professional and social calendars.

■ The Black Collegian Online (www.black-collegian.com) offers career advice and a state-by-state job database. And that's just a smattering.

For children, Shelton Jewette, owner of Computers 101, a Washington computer training center, recommends the Afro-Americ Kids Zone at www.afroam.org/children/children.html.

It includes fables, games, puzzles and brain teasers.

One place to start is www.everythingblack.com

The halls are haunted with schoolmates



Matthew Henry
Storyteller

SCHOOL OF GHOSTS

"Give me my pencil!" yelled Bryan in the middle of his third grade class.

"Bryan, that's a check mark," his teacher said, writing his name on the board.

"But George stole my pencil!"

"No buts, straight to detention!"

His friend George started laughing.

"George, you too," yelled Mrs. Davis.

"Mrs. Davis is the strictest teacher in the world," Bryan thought.

While Bryan and George were walking to detention, Bryan heard a noise. It came from Laura's locker. Inside he saw a neon green jewelry box.

"Come on, we'd better go," said George.

"No, wait," said Bryan. He opened the box and . . . Poooooffffff!!!!!! Bryan went flying backwards, right into George. When he got up, he thought he saw a ghost.

Bryan and George started running, and ran right into the principal.

"Oh, hi, Mr. Finch," they boys said.

"Hi, boys. What are you doing in such a rush?" he asked.

"Um, oh, um . . . look behind you!" The principal turned around.

"Now's my chance," thought Bryan. He started running down the hall. He was almost to the door when, bang! It slammed shut.

"Aaaaaahhhhh!" he yelled. "Ghosts everywhere!"

"Hey, Bryan, know our voices? I'm George. I'm Mrs. Davis. I'm Mr. Finch!"

"Aaaaaaaahhhhhh! Everyone has turned into ghosts! What am I going to do?" screamed Bryan.

"Don't panic," he said to himself. "It's only a dream." He shut his eyes and tapped his toes together saying, "There's no place like home, there's no place like home." He opened his eyes, and it wasn't a dream. He was still standing in the middle of the hall, surrounded by ghosts.

How would he get out? he wondered. His karate chop would not work. It would go right through the ghosts. Then Bryan remembered something. If you're in trouble, you have to stop, drop and roll, so that's exactly what he did. Then he remembered something else. He ran over to the office and grabbed the fire extinguisher. He started spraying everything, including the ghosts. They evaporated. "They're gone!" he said. "I'm free."

He stepped outside and there they all were, standing as if nothing had happened to them.

"I'll show them," he said. He ran back inside and grabbed a book titled "Incredibly Weird Creatures." He looked up Ghosts. Ghosts, it said, can be killed by someone being nice to them.

"Well," he said, "I guess I'll do it. It's the only way." He stepped back outside with a handful of cups and plates. "Who would like to join me for a tea party?" he asked the ghosts.

"Uh-oh," all the ghosts said. Poof! Two ghosts disappeared.

"I wish all my friends were like you!" Poof! Two more.

"You're my best friend!" Poof! All gone.

"No one wanted to join me for my tea party, I guess," Bryan said. He walked home, relieved that there were no more ghosts. When he got home, he heard someone talking in a deep voice.

"Do you know my voice?" it said. "Oh no, not again! groaned Bryan.

Each week, we give local kids a chance to tell a story. Today's Storyteller is Matthew Henry, 8, of Lansing, a third-grader at Post Oak Elementary.

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